



Trading Freedom for Safety



“Government agencies are taking advantage of insecurity being felt in the US to introduce legislation that will allow monitoring of communication”

Without doubt the most significant ‘event’ over the last month was the attack by terrorists on the World Trade Centre and the Pentagon. Their belief is that execution of the act was made possible by the use of encrypted communication technology.

Quite predictably, the initial reaction seems to be that similar events can be avoided in the future by monitoring all communications with the help of backdoors in all encryption software. There is a new legislation being suggested in the US that will allow law enforcement agencies to do just this.

This serves no real purpose because even though the US has disallowed the export of powerful encryption schemes, people outside have access to far more powerful and unknown encryption schemes. The new Bill that seeks support to add backdoors to encryption software will be limited to software developed only in the US. Any individual who wants to communicate in secret will not use a back-doored encryption scheme controlled by the US government when he can choose from several 1024-bit encryption schemes that aren’t in the control of the US government.

Government agencies in most developed countries are used to being in control of the flow of technology to people. However, due to the presence of a new economic structure which fuelled research and development in areas that were beyond the direct control of the government, this is no longer a reality. The power to choose what technology reaches people has now passed on into the hands of people in different parts of the world.

This is something that the security agencies aren’t particularly comfortable with.

Privacy activists insist that government agencies are taking advantage of the insecurity being felt by people in the US to introduce legislation that will allow them to monitor all communication. This would be accomplished by installing software called Carnivore on the ISPs’ servers, which would allow the monitoring of all kinds of communication, including personal e-mail. This is of concern not only to US citizens, but also to anyone who is using a US-based e-mail service.

It remains to be seen whether the legislation will be effective in preventing the occurrence of similar incidences in the future. However, this would eventually result in less freedom and violates the right to privacy that each of us feels we are entitled to on the Internet.

Is this a price worth paying?

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